Of course, leakages, corruption and systemic inefficiencies still remained, as a range of studies have documented. Yet, from the villagers' point of view, the scope for pilferage was reduced. 'You cannot move Rs 2 from here to there,' a long-time observer of such schemes in Lucknow told us. 'They have made their system so strong that through government the money goes directly into people's accounts—if it is Rs 200, Rs 200 reaches. The mentality has been that if it was Rs 2,000 earlier, then only Rs 200 would reach the village. So, people think that this guy has brought magic. The big difference is that you don't have to beg with your hands outstretched before anyone. That is what has changed.'[5]

Direct Benefit Transfers: Origins and Modi's Ramp-up

The village in Saharanpur exemplified the sea change in the rural welfare economy that DBT had wrought. Equally, it was an example of how an idea pushed through by Manmohan Singh at the fag end of UPA-2 was appropriated by the Modi government politically. The DBT programme was formally launched with much fanfare by Manmohan Singh's UPA-2 government on 1 January 2013. Then Rural Affairs Minister Jairam Ramesh even coined a political slogan for it: 'Aapka Paisa, Aapke Haath' (Your Money in Your Hands). It was launched after months of internal sparring among Congress ministers on the usage of Aadhaar. Once the objections were overcome, however, it was hailed at the time as the 'world's largest cash-transfer scheme'.

The political potential of it was clear even then. One observer saw it as the 'most historic one-shot transformative social policy instrument in India', 'on a par with the abolition of the *zamindari* system, the Green Revolution, banks nationalisation, the Right to Information and the National Rural Employment Guarantee Scheme'.[6] Political editors covering the BJP and the Congress both noted at the time that the launch of the scheme had brought the 'spring back into the step of Congress leaders'[7] after months of being on the defensive as they headed into an election year. The UPA initially launched DBT on a trial basis for twenty-four Union government schemes in forty-three districts.[8] The first trials